



YOU ARE **39 WEEKS AND 2 DAYS**

5 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

This close-up 3-D ultrasound view shows that this baby's earlobe is particularly prominent. The dark flecks around the ear look like hair but are in fact shadows (although many babies have hair at this stage).

“Your baby's bones have hardened to a certain degree, but this process will continue right up to the teenage years!”

Your baby's skeleton has gradually transformed, from soft cartilage to bone, a process called [ossification](#). This process starts in the center of each bone spreading outward. By the end of pregnancy, ossification is complete along the length of each bone, but the ends of the long bones and the tips of the bones in the fingers and toes remain as cartilage. This is necessary to allow later bone growth as the child develops.

The bones in the upper part of the skull are slightly different, developing from membranous structures rather than cartilage. These do not fully fuse until several years after birth and remain separated from each other by connective tissue. This connective tissue forms areas called sutures, and where more than two bones meet, wider spaces called fontanelles. Their function is to allow space for movement or “molding” between the skull bones making it easier for the head to descend into the pelvis during labor. It is also these suture lines and fontanelles that help your doctor determine the position of the baby's head during labor.

After delivery, you will notice that your baby's head shape is often elongated, but this soon changes as the bones realign back into their usual positions.